

Area of Study 3G – Sikhism

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Sikhism as a lived religion within the United Kingdom and throughout the world, and its beliefs and teachings on life, specifically about Philosophy of Religion and issues of equality and social justice.

There are four sections: Sikh Beliefs, Philosophy of Religion, Living the Sikh Life and Equality.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs, issues and practices to Sikhs today should be explored throughout the sections. This should include reference to how scripture informs a Sikh's understanding of the topics and how approaches to the issues are underpinned by philosophical arguments and ethical theory as applicable.

Students will be expected to study Sikhism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian. Students should compare and contrast the areas of belief and practice within Sikhism with Christianity as outlined in the content below.

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.4)*
- The practice and significance of worship (3.5)*

Students should recognise that Sikhism is one of the many religions and world views in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, Judaism, Sikhism and non-religious views such as Humanism and atheism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should compare and contrast the areas of ethics and/or philosophy within Sikhism and non-religious views as outlined in the content below.

Students should also recognise that within Sikhism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Sikhism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Khalsa and non-Khalsa Sikhs.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of God: how the characteristics of God are shown in the Mool Mantar, Guru Granth Sahib 1, and why the characteristics are important and why the Mool Mantar is significant for Sikhs.
1.2	God as Creator: the nature and importance of God as Creator (Karta Purakh) for Sikhs; Sikh teachings on God as Creator, including Guru Granth Sahib 12 and 94.
1.3	The nature of human life: the purpose and significance of life as an opportunity to unite with God; Sikh understandings of why uniting with God is important; how uniting with God will affect their lives, including Guru Granth Sahib 12.
1.4*	Sikh beliefs about life after death: the nature of karma, rebirth and mukti (liberation); how they are shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 2, 11 and 78; divergent understandings of how and why karma, rebirth and mukti are important for Sikh life today.
1.5	Purpose of life: the nature and importance of being gurmukh (God-centred) not manmukh (self-centred) and the elimination of haumai (ego/pride), including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 125 and 226; what actions make a gurmukh Sikh; divergent understandings of why being gurmukh and eliminating haumai is important in Sikh life today.
1.6	The oneness of humanity: how the equality of all humans is shown in the Guru Granth Sahib, including Guru Granth Sahib 349; how equality is shown in stories from the lives of the Gurus, including the example of Mai Bhago and the appointment of women as teachers; and how equality is shown in Sikh life today; how and why complete equality of men and women is important for Sikhs today.
1.7	Sewa (service to others): the nature of sewa, including tan, man and dhan; the origins and purpose of sewa and its importance in the development of Sikhism, including Guru Granth Sahib 26; divergent understandings of the practice and importance of sewa in Sikh life today in reflecting the priority of service to others.
1.8	Sangat: the nature and history of the sangat; divergent understandings of why the sangat is important for Sikhs, including Guru Granth Sahib 1316; the concept of Sat Sangat and divergent understandings of its significance for Sikhs; problems for Sikhs living without a sangat.

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	Revelation as proof of the existence of God: the meaning of the word Gurbani and the revelation to Guru Nanak during the River Experience as narrated in the Janamsakhis and Guru Granth Sahib 1; reasons why revelation might be important to Sikhs and why it might not be; what revelation shows about the nature of God for Sikhs.
2.2	Visions/mystical experiences as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of visions/mystical experiences in Sikhism and their use as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; scriptural examples, including Guru Granth Sahib 263; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of God for Sikhs and Sikh responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that visions are hallucinations and provide no proof that God exists; what visions show about the nature of God for Sikhs.
2.3	Sikh attitudes towards numinous experiences and enlightenment: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and importance of numinous experiences and enlightenment; scriptural examples, including Guru Granth Sahib 448–1–7 and non-religious examples of numinous experiences; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of God for Sikhs; Humanist and atheist responses to numinous experiences and enlightenment and Sikh responses to them.
2.4	Miracles as proof of the existence of God: the nature and importance of miracles in Sikhism, including why Guru Nanak did not work them on demand, with reference to Guru Granth Sahib 14; examples of miracles; reasons why they might lead to belief in the existence of God and Sikh responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) which maintain that miracles can be scientifically explained and provide no proof that God exists; divergent understandings of what miracles show about the nature of God for Sikhs.
2.5	Sikh attitudes towards religious experiences: Sikh attitudes towards religious experiences and its use as a philosophical argument for the existence of God: the nature of a religious experience within Sikhism, including Guru Granth Sahib 1402; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of religious experiences in Sikhism; Sikh responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments that religious experiences do not provide proof that God exists.
2.6	Design argument: the design argument and its use in Sikhism as a philosophical argument for the existence of God and what it shows about the nature of God; divergent understandings of the nature and importance of the design argument for the existence of God in Sikhism, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 463; Sikh responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the design argument as evidence for the existence of God.
2.7	Cosmological argument: the cosmological argument for the existence of God and its use in Sikhism as a philosophical argument for the existence of God; what the cosmological argument shows about the nature of God in Sikhism, including Guru Granth Sahib 1; divergent understandings of the strengths and challenges of the cosmological argument in Sikhism; Sikh responses to non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments against the cosmological argument as evidence for the existence of God.

Students should have an understanding of:

3.1	Features of the gurdwara: the nature, history and purpose of the design of the Gurdwara as the 'Door/Gate of the Guru', including Rahit Maryada Chapters 4–6; how and why objects of devotion are used within the gurdwara: Guru Granth Sahib, takht, chanani, chaur, the langar hall, four doors, and the Nishan Sahib; divergent understandings of the importance of these features in Sikh life today.
3.2	The gurdwara: the role and importance of the gurdwara within the Sikh community including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 1391; activities that take place within the gurdwara and why; the nature and importance of visiting Sikh historical gurdwaras: the Harmandir Sahib in Amritsar (the Golden Temple); divergent understandings of the importance of making such visits, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 4.
3.3	Langar: the history of langar including Guru Granth Sahib 967; the nature and purposes of langar; the significance of langar for Sikhs today, especially as an expression of sewa.
3.4	Nam Japna – meditating on the name of God: the nature and significance of Nam Japna; diverse ways in which the Nam Japna is used in the gurdwara and in Sikh daily life, including Guru Granth Sahib 1142.
3.5*	Prayer, including reference to Guru Granth Sahib 305: the nature, role and purpose of prayer in the home; the different types of prayer; when prayer might take place and why; the importance of having different prayers.
3.6	Akhand path (continuous 48-hour reading of the Guru Granth Sahib): the nature, history, role and purpose of the akhand path including reference Rahit Maryada Chapter 7; how and why Sikhs might take part in the akhand path: why the akhand path is important for the Sikh community and for individual Sikhs.
3.7	Gurpurbs and commemorations: divergent understandings of the nature, history and purpose of gurpurbs and commemorations; why they are important for Sikhs today. The origins and meaning of gurpurbs, including Guru Nanak's birthday, Vaisakhi, including reference to the account of the events found in Gurbilas Patshahi 10. Divali: the origins and meaning of commemorations, including the martyrdom of Guru Arjan and Guru Tagh Bahadur Ji.
3.8	Birth and naming rituals and ceremonies: the celebration and significance of Naam Karan and Hukamnama; the significance of Amrit Sanskar (the initiation ceremony) for Sikh families, including reference to the Rahit Maryada Chapters 11 and 13; divergent understandings of these ceremonies between khalsa and non-khalsa Sikhs; the significance of the names Singh and Kaur in the naming and Amrit ceremonies, and for Sikh identity today.

Students should have an understanding of:

4.1	Sikh teaching on human rights: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and purpose of human rights; why Sikhs might support human rights as important, including Guru Granth Sahib 300; divergent Sikh responses to the need for and application of individual human rights, including the support offered by situation ethics; the problems human rights might cause for Sikhs; non-religious (including atheist and Humanist) arguments and Sikh responses to them.
4.2	Sikh attitudes towards equality: Sikh teachings and responses to the causes of inequality and problems caused by inequality in the world with reference to examples; Sikh teachings and practices that reflect equality, including Guru Granth Sahib 349; possible Sikh solutions to inequality and why Sikhs may support them.
4.3	Sikh attitudes towards religious freedom: different Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and importance of religious freedom, including Guru Gobind Singh, Dasam Granth 51; the divergent responses of Sikhs to a multi-faith society; the benefits and challenges for Sikhs living in a multi-faith society; Sikh responses to non-religious arguments (including atheist and Humanist) against aspects of religious freedom.
4.4	Sikh attitudes to prejudice and discrimination: Sikh teachings and responses to the nature of prejudice and discrimination, and the problems they cause, including links to situation ethics; Sikh teachings on why prejudice and discrimination against religions is wrong, including Guru Arjan, Asa 385.
4.5	Sikh attitudes towards racial harmony: Sikh teachings about racial harmony; different reasons and ways Sikhs have worked for racial harmony, including teachings on racial harmony, including Guru Granth Sahib 345, and those that may reflect situation ethics; the benefits for Sikhs of living in a multi-ethnic society.
4.6	Sikh teachings and attitudes towards racial discrimination: Sikh teachings about why it causes problems in society, including Guru Granth Sahib 300; Sikh responses to racial discrimination as shown in the life and teachings of Guru Nanak and those teachings that may reflect ethical theories such as situation ethics; Humanist and atheistic responses to racial discrimination.
4.7	Sikh attitudes to social justice: divergent Sikh responses to and teachings about the nature of the distribution of wealth and opportunity in the UK and the world; Sikh teaching about social justice, including the concepts supporting 'Deg Tegh Fateh' for khalsa and non-khalsa Sikhs and how these concepts are expressed in the Rahit Maryada Chapter 12; the different ways Sikhs work for social justice and how these may link to situation ethics.
4.8	Sikh attitudes towards wealth and poverty: divergent Sikh teachings and responses to the nature and causes of poverty in the UK and in the world; Sikh teachings about wealth and poverty, including Guru Granth Sahib 1159, and how these may link to ethical theory.